conquered the rest of Burma in the 1880s, the province was included in colonial Burma and, as a consequence, became part of Burma on independence in 1948. At that same time its administrative title was changed from Arakan to Rakhine.

Early history (to 1000 AD)

Burma

Archaeological evidence suggests that the earliest human settlements in modern-day Myanmar date back to 11,000 BC. By around 6000 BC there is evidence of a more settled culture, with cave paintings depicting domesticated animals.[7] One of the earliest sites showing evidence of agriculture has been found near Mandalay, and dates to around 500 BC. The styles of pottery, iron working and burial practice all show close links with those practised in Thailand and Cambodia at the same time. This suggests that the earliest settlements in central Myanmar were culturally linked to those elsewhere in South East Asia and that the earliest settlers in the region were related to other ethnic groups prevalent in South Asia. Groups such as the Mon (who live in the southern corner of Burma) still have much ethnically in common with the Khmers of Cambodia.

The first walled cities in the region appeared around 200 BC.[8] These showed design features common both to India and to Thailand, indicating the diffusion of Indian norms and culture across South East Asia in this period. Indian approaches to city-planning dominated, as did both Hinduism and Buddhism. These new religions arrived in the region at this period and mixed with the older indigenous animist beliefs. At this stage, central Myanmar was ethnically split between the Mon, who lived in the south, and the Pyu, who lived in the north.[9]

The Mon are widely credited with bringing Theravada Buddhism to Myanmar through their trading links with Sri Lanka. However, this did not immediately lead to the dominance of Buddhism, and the archaeological record of their main coastal city, Thaton, contains examples of both Buddhist and Hindu art. The city was conquered by the emerging Pagan Kingdom at the beginning of the eleventh century AD, marking the end of an independent Mon Kingdom, and the Mon were then largely absorbed